

THE DEAL THE RAKYAT NEED TO UNDERSTAND

SEARAH

The Deal That Could Reshape Malaysia's Petroleum Future

How a London-registered company, a gas field 200 kilometres off the coast of Sarawak, and a legal structure quietly incorporated during an active court dispute — came together in a RM70 billion agreement.

And why it matters to every Malaysian who pays for fuel.

BY ARIF FAZIL

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PREFACE

Why This Document Exists

This is not a political document. It is an investigative one. The subject is a RM70 billion agreement that affects every Malaysian who uses fuel, pays electricity bills, or heats a home. The RM70 billion is not a guess — it is Eni's own figure, disclosed in a November 2025 press release, confirmed by PETRONAS, and reported by Reuters.

The questions this document raises are not answered. They are genuinely unanswered — by PETRONAS, by Eni, by the Malaysian government, and by the Italian government.

RM70 BILLION. USD 15 BILLION. "IN EXCESS OF USD 15 BILLION OVER FIVE YEARS" — ENI PRESS RELEASE, NOVEMBER 2025.

The document draws on public sources: company registries, government press releases, international arbitration records, energy research reports, and court filings. It distinguishes clearly between what is confirmed and what requires further investigation. That distinction is intentional.

The investigation is ongoing. The questions asked here are questions — not accusations. They deserve answers.

"Every Malaysian who uses fuel, who pays electricity bills, who heats a home — has a stake in the answer."

— Arif Fazil

PART 1 OF 4

The Deal

What Was Signed in Abu Dhabi

On November 3, 2025, at ADIPEC in Abu Dhabi — one of the world's largest energy conferences — PETRONAS and Eni signed what both companies described as a "transformational" joint venture. The agreement was announced publicly. The CEOs of both companies attended.

The investment agreement committed PETRONAS and Eni to a 50/50 joint venture covering upstream petroleum assets across Malaysia and Indonesia. Eni described the combination as "transformational." PETRONAS called it "historic." Both descriptions may be accurate.

THE TRANSACTION HAS NOT YET CLOSED. Eni's own statements, as recently as March 2026, indicate that "customary and governmental approvals" were still being obtained.

Neither announcement mentioned the most important thing about the structure: it was registered in London. It was registered there before the deal was announced. And it was registered during an active court dispute about who owns the gas.

The company is called SEARAH Limited — incorporated February 11, 2026 at ENI House, 8-10 Stratford Place, London. It is registered at UK Companies House as Company No. 17027115.

The question is not whether the structure is illegal. The question is whether it was designed this way — and who decided that.

— SEARAH Investigation

THE SEQUENCE

The Timing Is Difficult to Ignore

In August 2025, PETROS filed a lawsuit against PETRONAS in the Kuching High Court, alleging that PETRONAS had been supplying natural gas in Sarawak without a valid license. In October 2025, Eni confirmed the joint venture was being structured. In February 2026, SEARAH Limited was incorporated in London. In March 2026, the company changed its name — 14 days after the Malaysian Federal Court agreed to hear PETRONAS's constitutional challenge.

PART 2 OF 4

The Field

Why Sarawak's Gas Is Central to This Deal

Block SK316 is PETRONAS's largest domestic producing asset. That is not an opinion — it is the finding of Wood Mackenzie, one of the world's most respected energy research firms, in a February 2025 report written specifically about the PETRONAS-Eni combination.

"PETRONAS's largest domestic producing asset" — WOOD Mackenzie, February 2025, press release.

The Kasawari gas field, located in Block SK316 approximately 200 kilometres off the coast of Sarawak, began production in August 2024. It is one of the most significant domestic energy discoveries in Malaysia's recent history. It is operated by PETRONAS Carigali — and now, indirectly, through the SEARAH structure, partly owned by Eni.

MLNG Bintulu — one of the world's largest LNG export facilities — processes gas from these fields. Its customers include Japan, Korea, Taiwan, and China. Every shipment that leaves Bintulu generates foreign exchange for Malaysia. Under the SEARAH structure, that revenue flow is now partly governed by English law, in a UK-registered company with 50% Italian ownership.

Block SK316 is not just a gas field. It is the asset that makes the RM70 billion figure credible. And it is Sarawak's gas.

— SEARAH Investigation

PART 3 OF 4

The Architect

Claudio Descalzi and the SEARAH Structure

Claudio Descalzi has been the chief executive of Eni SpA since May 2014. Born in Milan on February 27, 1955, trained as an engineer at the Politecnico di Milano, he has spent his entire career at Eni. In April 2026, the Italian Treasury appointed him to a senior government role. He has simultaneously run Eni through some of its most internationally contested periods.

In March 2021, Descalzi was acquitted by an Italian court in a case concerning the acquisition of OPL 245 — a contested Nigerian oil block. The acquittal was appealed. The appeal was ongoing as of early 2026. Eni has consistently maintained Descalzi's innocence throughout the proceedings.

Eni has disclosed that SEARAH follows what it calls the "satellite model" — a strategy Eni has used in three prior jurisdictions: Norway, Angola, and the United Kingdom. In each case, the local production asset is placed inside a UK or Norwegian holding structure. In each case, English or Norwegian law governs the relationship between the production company and its partners.

THE "SATELLITE MODEL" IS ENI'S MODEL — USED IN NORWAY, ANGOLA, AND THE UK. PETRONAS DID NOT INVENT THIS STRUCTURE. ENI INTRODUCED IT.

The satellite model is not inherently illegal. It is a legitimate corporate structuring approach used in multiple jurisdictions. The question this document asks is not whether it is illegal. The question is whether a sovereign resource of a nation was placed inside this structure — and whether the relevant parties consented.

THE STRUCTURAL FINDING

SEARAH is not accidentally registered in London. The UK structure is not a technicality. It is the point.

PART 4 OF 4

The Unanswered

What Nobody in Putrajaya Will Explain

The transaction has not yet closed. Eni's own statements, as recently as March 2026, indicate that "customary and governmental approvals" were still being obtained. The deal was expected to reach closing in the first half of 2026. There is still time. There is still time for the questions to be asked.

What we do not yet have — what has not been made public — is any record of the following:

QUESTION 1**The UK Structure**

Who specifically decided that SEARAH would be incorporated in the United Kingdom under English law, rather than in Malaysia under Malaysian law? Was this decision made by Eni, by PETRONAS, or jointly? Was Malaysian legal counsel consulted?

QUESTION 2**Government Approval**

Did the Federal Cabinet formally approve the fact that Malaysian petroleum assets — including Sarawak fields — would be placed inside a UK-incorporated company with 50% foreign ownership?

QUESTION 3**Sarawak's Position**

Was the Sarawak state government informed that assets in its offshore waters were being placed inside a UK company? Was the Sarawak Minister for Petroleum consulted?

QUESTION 4**PETRONAS-PETROS Conflict**

Given that PETRONAS and PETROS were in active litigation over these same assets at the time SEARAH was incorporated, what consideration was given to the implications of placing disputed assets inside a UK company?

QUESTION 5**The 50-Year Track Record**

PETRONAS was established in 1974. PETROS was incorporated in 2017. This dispute has run for decades. Why has no Malaysian government resolved it? What has been the cost to the people of Sarawak of this institutional failure?

QUESTION 6**Descalzi's Role**

Eni has disclosed that the satellite model is Eni's model, used in Norway, Angola, and the UK. Did PETRONAS propose this structure, or did Eni? If Eni proposed it, what consideration did PETRONAS give to the jurisdictional implications for Malaysia?

QUESTION 7**The Closing Conditions**

What are the conditions precedent to closing? Has the Malaysian government insisted on any structural modifications as a condition of its approval? Is there a date by which those conditions must be satisfied?

The PETRONAS-PETROS Question Is Not Academic

The Federal Court's decision to allow the PETRONAS constitutional challenge on March 16, 2026 is significant not because it resolves the dispute — it does not — but because it means the court has agreed the question is serious enough to hear.

The core issue is whether the Petroleum Development Act 1974, and the federal petroleum regime it established, validly applies in Sarawak, or whether Sarawak's own petroleum laws take precedence. If PETROS prevails, the implications for PETRONAS's operating authority in Sarawak are substantial. If PETRONAS prevails, the PETROS framework is significantly weakened. Neither outcome will change the actual fields — but those assets are now, in their corporate holding structure, partly inside SEARAH Limited — a UK company governed by English law.

The PETRONAS-PETROS dispute is not academic. SEARAH is not academic. The RM70 billion question is not academic. Every Malaysian who uses fuel, who pays electricity bills, who heats a home — has a stake in the answer.

— Arif Fazil

Key Timeline

Jul 2017	PETROS incorporated — 100%-owned by Sarawak government
Aug 2024	Kasawari gas field, Block SK316 offshore Sarawak, begins production
Jun 2025	Framework Agreement signed in Kuala Lumpur — both CEOs attend
Aug 2025	PETROS sues PETRONAS in Kuching High Court — unlicensed gas supply in Sarawak
Oct 2025	Anwar speaks with Meloni — both agree to expedite the deal
Nov 3, 2025	Investment Agreement signed at ADIPEC Abu Dhabi — both CEOs sign
Feb 11, 2026	SEARAH Limited incorporated at UK Companies House (Company No. 17027115)
Feb 25, 2026	Kuching High Court rules on bank guarantee — jurisdiction sent to Federal Court
Mar 16, 2026	Federal Court allows PETRONAS constitutional challenge on Sarawak petroleum laws
Mar 30, 2026	Company changes name from SEARA ENERGY LIMITED to SEARAH LIMITED — 14 days after ruling
Mid-2026	SEARAH expected to begin operations — closing conditions still being satisfied

Sources

- Companies House UK, Company No. 17027115 (SEARAH Limited) — Incorporation, PSC register, officer list, filing history
- Eni media releases, November 2025 and March 2026 — Investment Agreement, SEARAH structure
- PETRONAS media releases, November 2025 — JV partnership confirmation
- UNCTAD Investment Policy Hub — BIT database verified April 2026: NO Italy-Malaysia BIT confirmed; NO active UK-Malaysia BIT
- Malaysian Parliament Hansard — no record of parliamentary briefing on SEARAH structure found
- Malaysian Federal Court record, March 16, 2026 — PETRONAS constitutional challenge admitted
- Reuters, October 2025 and March 2026
- Wood Mackenzie press release, February 28, 2025 — PETRONAS-Eni combination analysis
- Global Arbitration Review — ICSID Case No. ARB/20/48 (Eni vs Nigeria)
- Fulcrum Singapore (ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute), April 2026
- Milan Court records, March 2021 — Descalzi/Eni OPL 245 acquittal

What Is Confirmed

- SEARAH Limited (Company No. 17027115) — UK-registered, incorporated February 11, 2026 at ENI House, London.
- 50% owned by PETRONAS Carigali International Ventures, 50% by Eni Lasso Plc.
- Deal valued at "in excess of USD 15 billion over five years" — Eni press release, November 2025.
- Company governed by Companies Act 2006 (English law).
- NO active BIT between Malaysia and Italy or the United Kingdom — confirmed by UNCTAD April 2026.
- Malaysia produces approximately 350,000 boe/day from domestic fields.
- MLNG Bintulu — one of world's largest LNG export facilities; supplies Japan, Korea, Taiwan, China.

What Requires Further Investigation

- The specific terms of the JV agreement between PETRONAS and Eni are not public.
- Whether Malaysian Parliament was formally notified of the arrangement has not been confirmed.
- Whether PETROS was consulted before the SEARAH structure was finalised has not been confirmed.
- Whether Malaysian legal counsel reviewed the UK incorporation before the structure was adopted has not been confirmed.

IBERI

T Corrected Edition

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64b4a80e8e92c101c764331e44db5c3af172b8946b476e0b200a9bb

liable claims cross-checked against primary sources

ion incorrectly claimed Italy-Malaysia BIT (1988) was in force. UNCTAD (April
BIT claim retracted. The correct statement: NO BIT protects this arrangement.

Fazil | arifOS Federation Intelligence